

the optimal audio experience that they were designed for. Burning in a set of drivers refers to continuously playing music/white noise/frequency sweeps, and prescribed burn-in periods can be as long as a few hundred hours. As with most conventional knowledge, there isn't any exact universally agreed upon method. Proponents of this myth rationalise their claim with the logic that the cones are stiff when new and the burn in period helps them gain the flexibility needed to deliver a complete aural experience. However, they seem to neglect the fact that if the headphones were designed to be burned in, the manufacturers would do that at the factory itself. There is also the possibility that this myth is perpetrated as a marketing tactic, or to get users to keep the product past the return period.

The core of this claim is enhanced audio quality, and that is a very subjective issue as there is no standard framework for measuring quality. As far as the science goes, this myth is like God – can't be proved, nor disproved. While audio quality cannot be measured, the physical changes in the driver performance can, and have been experimentally recorded. Tyll Hertsens at Inner Fidelity tested this myth using two AKG Q701 headphones. After prescribing one of them to 90 hours of burn-in, the data showed a slight change in the frequency response as compared to the pristine pair, however the difference wasn't pronounced enough to be deemed noteworthy. When even mountains wear down over time, what is a pair of cans? Just as a new pair of shoes get more comfortable after prolonged use, perhaps earphones start to sound better as well. Then again, it is more likely to be placebo, because there is no evidence to support the myth that you must burn in your swanky new headphones, and even if you do, it certainly won't result in a stark improvement.

Myth #2 - Digital reproduction can never come close to analog sound!

There are some who believe that lossless is a marketing term, digital audio chops sound into parts so is always lossy, and therefore never as good as analog audio. Those of you who've read through Chapter 7 should immediately recognize this as a myth. There is mathematical proof that an analog signal can be exactly reproduced after digital sampling, given a high enough sample rate. While it is true that low resolution digital audio can sound grainy, even compressed mp3 sounds very good with decent speakers. Some people swear by vinyl records, and a few artists like Norah Jones always record analog music, but even then behind the scenes it's usually found that a high-quality digital signal is being remastered to analog audio.